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Newsmakers

GYANESH KUMAR, 61
Chief Election Commissioner

Special Intensive Role

Efforts to clean voter rolls through the Special Intensive Revision made Gyanesh Kumar a constant political target, as reform collided with mistrust and Opposition resistance

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**



PTI

Gyanesh Kumar's arrival at Nirvachan Sadan in February 2025 came with an institutional redesign. As the first chief election commissioner appointed under the reworked 2023 law, one that quietly clipped judicial influence from the selection panel, his elevation itself became a political flashpoint. The Opposition saw in the new system a tilt toward executive dominance. The government described it as a rationalisation. Kumar—a veteran bureaucrat who had long mastered the art of surviving shifting constitutional weather—insisted that the Election Commission remained independent. However, it was clear that his tenure would be measured less by proclamations and more by whether he could rebuild trust in a political climate allergic to consensus.

Kumar began by moving fast. Within his first 100 days in office, he unveiled a sprawling 21-point reform agenda that included capping voter load per booth at 1,200 to reduce crowding, redesigning voter slips to make them clearer, expanding polling stations into dense urban enclaves, acknowledging the changing geography of India's electorate. Alongside technical fixes, Kumar initiated the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Bihar, a sweeping exercise to purge outdated, duplicate and fraudulent entries. It became the template for a clean-up that he intends to replicate across the country. For Kumar, the rolls were the bedrock. If they were unreliable, every other reform risked becoming cosmetic. For the Opposition, it appeared as another tactic to help the ruling BJP win, this time by tweaking the rolls. In mid-year, Rahul Gandhi unleashed a fusillade of allegations, claiming the 2024 general election had been tainted by "vote theft" and padded rolls. For weeks, Indian politics descended into a familiar theatre

The voter roll clean-up Kumar initiated in Bihar appeared to the Opposition as yet another tactic to advantage the ruling BJP in the state polls